

Jubilant team: Karnataka triumphed over Vidarbha in a nail-biting thriller to claim the Vijay Hazare Trophy in Vadodara. THE HINDU



followed it up with a vital 86 in the semis. Meanwhile, after enduring a string of low scores, Shrijith struck 78 in a 160-run alliance with Smaran in the final to tip the scales in Karnataka's favour.

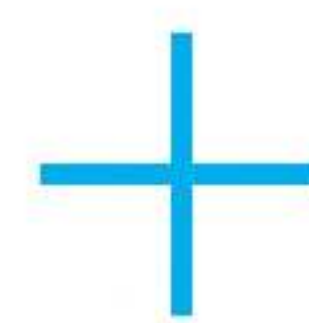
Mayank, the tournament's second highest accumulator with 651 runs, had set the league stage on fire, plundering four centuries and a fifty but could only eke out 38 runs in three innings in the knockouts, putting the onus on an inexperienced middle-order.

Karnataka's newly appointed No. 3, Aneesh, who also made his List A debut this season, impressed with three consecutive fifties and got off

to good starts in the semis and final.

"[It] feels amazing to have won this after a while. It's just that we turned up and won those crucial moments. [A] lot of the youngsters stepped up. **We are a team in transition — four guys from this team have made their debut, and a lot of them are just playing their second season,**" a relieved Mayank said after the final.

Karnataka's chief selector, J. Abhiram, viewed the title win as a vindication of the team management's decision to move on from the likes of Manish Pandey ahead of the season.



Winner: Karnataka
Runner-up: Vidarbha
Top run-scorer: Karun Nair (779 runs)
Top wicket-taker: Arshdeep Singh (20 wickets)